

Chapter 85-1

Wang Ruoshi had a friend beside her who tugged at her arm, wanting to pull her away, but Wang Ruoshi shook off her friend's hand and frowned as she scolded: "Don't."

The friend was helpless and said in a low voice: "Let's go."

"I'm not leaving." Wang Ruoshi said: "I finally ran into Liang Shi. Of course I have to get to the bottom of this."

Wang Ruoshi ignored Xu Qingzhu's anger and only looked at Liang Shi. "Why haven't you been answering my calls?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Since taking over the original owner's phone and social media apps, Liang Shi didn't know how many numbers she had blocked.

It was very possible that one day she had received a call from this person and then blocked her.

And then never answered again.

Even if she had answered, Liang Shi couldn't possibly have chatted with her anyway.

Liang Shi was dazed for two seconds, then quickly gathered her thoughts. "What exactly do you want to say?"

Wang Ruoshi paused. "I want to ask when you're getting divorced. You said you'd divorce her once you were done playing with her."

She said it so self-righteously—the original owner must have given her a very definite promise before.

Liang Shi helplessly pressed her hand to her forehead. "This has nothing to do with you."

"How does it have nothing to do with me?" Wang Ruoshi said angrily: "After the divorce, you're supposed to marry me, of course."

Liang Shi: "..."

Even the friend standing beside her couldn't bear to listen anymore and just wanted to drag her away.

Xu Qingzhu opposite them had daggers shooting from her eyes, but Wang Ruoshi was fearless. "Hurry up and tell me, when are you getting divorced?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Before Xu Qingzhu could speak, she took a deep breath to calm her emotions and said to Wang Ruoshi: "Come with me. Let's talk."

Then she looked at Xu Qingzhu, leaned in and said in a low voice: "Let me handle this."

This was the original owner's mess to begin with. She was the only one who could clean it up.

Having Xu Qingzhu handle it... that would be too much of a jerk move.

Liang Shi led Wang Ruoshi to a more secluded spot. Xu Qingzhu stood not far away, but she wasn't watching them—she had turned her back to look at the sea.

Her figure was straight and slender. Standing by the sea, she was a beautiful sight to behold.

If eyes were cameras, they could capture her elegance at any moment.

After a moment, Liang Shi withdrew her gaze from Xu Qingzhu.

She herself hadn't noticed that when she looked at Xu Qingzhu, her gaze was gentle and indulgent, with the corners of her lips slightly raised in a soft smile.

But when facing Wang Ruoshi, she had a cold and indifferent demeanor.

All of this was seen by Wang Ruoshi. Wang Ruoshi clenched her fists in anger and questioned coldly: "Did you forget?"

"Forget what?" Liang Shi's voice held no warmth.

Her height was enough for her to look down at Wang Ruoshi. The other woman stood on the beach, looking up at her with reddened eyes, like an abandoned little white rabbit.

But Liang Shi couldn't muster any compassion.

"Forget our promise." Wang Ruoshi sniffled and said aggrievedly: "You said you were going to divorce your wife, but what are you doing now? You're actually wearing couple's outfits and coming to see the ocean with her. Don't tell me this is your pre-divorce romance! I don't want to hear it!"

"I wasn't going to say that anyway." Liang Shi said: "Why should I tell you about matters between me and my wife?"

Wang Ruoshi: "?"

She was stunned.

No, this wasn't how things were supposed to develop?

When she said she didn't want to hear it, wasn't Liang Shi supposed to anxiously explain to her?

Why was Liang Shi so cold?

This didn't make sense.

In the past, all her girlfriends had coaxed and pampered her. How was it that with Liang Shi, she had been taken advantage of in bed, and now when they met again, even acting cute didn't work?

"No, you have to tell me." Wang Ruoshi said: "I want to hear your explanation."

"Why should I explain anything to you?" Liang Shi said coldly.

Wang Ruoshi: "..."

"You!" Wang Ruoshi was so aggrieved she was about to cry. "You're too much!"

"Miss Wang." Liang Shi said neither humbly nor arrogantly: "In the past, I may have said some inappropriate things and done some inappropriate things, but I never promised you anything. So things between us are over. You have no right to meddle in my affairs."

Wang Ruoshi was stunned. "What do you mean?"

"Don't come bother me again in the future." Liang Shi said: "I wish you meet a better person and have a better life."

After saying this, she turned to leave, but Wang Ruoshi grabbed her and questioned in shock: "Are you saying everything that happened between us doesn't count?"

"What happened between us?" Liang Shi asked back.

"That day... at the bar, you... you slept with me." Wang Ruoshi said: "Did you forget all of it?"

Liang Shi closed her eyes briefly: "But I definitely never promised to marry you."

Wang Ruoshi: "..."

"Since you're getting divorced, wouldn't it be good to marry me?" Wang Ruoshi asked back.

Liang Shi said coldly: "No."

"First of all." Liang Shi glanced sideways at the hand Wang Ruoshi had placed on her, reached out to remove it, and then said methodically: "Matters between me and my wife only concern the two of us. You have no right to ask about them. Secondly, I never promised you anything. What happened back then was consensual between both parties. What happened that day ended that day—don't come pestering me after the fact. Third, I've never had a good impression of people who knowingly become homewreckers."¹

Wang Ruoshi was dumbfounded. She pointed at herself. "You're saying I... knowingly became a homewrecker? I... I..."

She wanted to find a point to refute, but was so angry she started stuttering. It took a while before she could get the words out. "I didn't! It was you who back then..."

"Did I ever hide my married status from you?" Liang Shi asked back.

Wang Ruoshi shook her head. "No. But..."

Liang Shi said coldly: "There are no buts."

Wang Ruoshi: "?"

Liang Shi's tone carried disgust. "Miss Wang, no matter how broken someone else's relationship is, that's not an excuse for you to insert yourself into it."

Wang Ruoshi: "..."

Wang Ruoshi was dazed for a few seconds. By the time she came back to her senses, Liang Shi had already walked some distance away.

Looking at that tall, slender figure from behind, Wang Ruoshi suddenly shouted: "What about you then? You have a wife and you're still picking up people at bars. What does that make you?!"

Liang Shi's footsteps paused. After a moment, she answered through gritted teeth: "Trash."

Wang Ruoshi: "?"

She really hadn't expected that Liang Shi would even insult herself.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Knowingly become a homewrecker" (知三當三):** A Chinese internet slang term that literally means "knowing [they're the] third [party] and still being the third [party]." It refers to someone who knowingly enters into a relationship with a person who is already married or in a committed relationship—essentially being a willing homewrecker or "the other woman/man."

Chapter 85-2

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At first, Liang Shi had also been caught off guard by this sudden incident and hadn't thought through the logic at all.

It was only while leading Wang Ruoshi to a secluded spot that she sorted things out.

Regardless of the reason, the original owner had liked Xu Qingzhu—and it was a very special, very intense kind of liking, even to the point of being obsessive.

Moreover, the original owner had a sex addiction and had many casual partners in the past. Who knew if there were still any regular bed partners.

Under these circumstances, how could the original owner possibly have told someone else that she would marry them after the divorce?

Most likely, she had just paid them off with money.

And Wang Ruoshi wasn't that clever either. She kept saying "you're going to divorce," and her assumption that she would marry her after the divorce was just wishful thinking.

So Liang Shi speculated that the original owner had probably drunk too much and told someone about divorcing Xu Qingzhu, but she couldn't possibly have promised to marry the other person.

Wang Ruoshi was probably eyeing Liang Shi's money and wanted to use this opportunity to climb up the social ladder.

By the time Liang Shi walked back to find Xu Qingzhu, she discovered that Xu Qingzhu was already buying things from a vendor by the beach.

She seemed not to care at all about what had just happened.

However, this incident served as a wake-up call for Liang Shi.

She didn't know how many people the original owner had been involved with before, or how many more "Wang Ruoshis" might come knocking in the future.

She could only secretly pray that the original owner had properly dealt with all those old lovers and casual partners.

Meanwhile, Wang Ruoshi walked away with red-rimmed eyes. Her friend sighed helplessly. "I already told you not to get entangled with these rich people, but you just wouldn't listen."

"Do you know what she just called me?" Wang Ruoshi still seemed in disbelief.

"What?" her friend asked.

Wang Ruoshi's tears fell. "She called me a knowing homewrecker. Wuwuwu."

Friend: "...Aren't you though?"

Wang Ruoshi: "?"

"You knew from the start that she had a wife. And didn't you take five hundred thousand that day?" The friend said: "This matter is over. Don't dream about marrying into a wealthy family anymore. That's not something people like us can aspire to."

Wang Ruoshi: "?"

She was furious. "Are you even my friend?"

The friend who wanted to persuade her a bit more suddenly paused, opened and closed her mouth awkwardly, and just nodded in a daze: "Yes."

"Then why do you keep speaking up for her?" Wang Ruoshi was angry.

The friend pressed her lips together. After a moment, she cursed: "She's trash too! Having a wife and still going out to hook up! She doesn't deserve her wife at all!"

Wang Ruoshi: "...You know her wife?"

"She's the heiress of Minghui Jewelry." The friend took out her phone to show her. "Beautiful and highly educated. Truly the ideal woman."

Wang Ruoshi pushed her phone away and said through gritted teeth: "Just wait!"

"For what?" the friend asked.

Wang Ruoshi clenched her fist: "In the future, I'll definitely marry someone a hundred times better than Liang Shi!"

Friend: "..."

Chapter 85-3

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After Liang Shi returned to Xu Qingzhu's side, Xu Qingzhu didn't say anything—she just had her pay for a hair clip.

The two walked side by side along the beach again. The afterglow of the sunset scattered across the sea, dyeing the rippling water golden. The lingering light kept rolling across the surface of the ocean.

The boundless blue and golden yellow of the sea reflected off each other. The people playing on the beach gradually dispersed, and the place returned to silence.

The setting sun soon hid behind the mountains, leaving only the dim sky.

The wind was strong in the evening. Liang Shi's feet kicked up sand. Several times she wanted to explain to Xu Qingzhu, but didn't know how to begin.

It often started with words on the tip of her tongue and ended with a sigh.

Until Xu Qingzhu's hair tie fell onto the beach, and her long hair was instantly whipped into a wild dance by the wind.

Liang Shi picked up her hair tie and pulled her back from behind. The two were extremely close—just a bit more and they would be in an embrace.

"Your hair tie fell." Liang Shi said. "Your hair is messy."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu lifted her hair and opened the hair clip she had been holding in her hand. Her hair wrapped around her slender, pale fingers a few times, and then she clipped it up with the pearl hair clip, revealing the smooth and elegant lines of her neck.

The balance between cold and gentle temperament was perfectly captured.

After a long while, Liang Shi finally opened her mouth to explain: "That wasn't me."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "I know."

"I don't know how many sexual partners she had." Liang Shi said: "You can check the phone. I haven't done anything to wrong you since I arrived."

Xu Qingzhu then asked her: "When did you arrive?"

Liang Shi: "...It was during your heat period."

Xu Qingzhu responded with a flat "oh."

"I don't know how many sexual partners she had either." Xu Qingzhu said: "I've seen that one before."

Liang Shi: "?"

"When?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu crossed her arms, pulling her cardigan tighter, but the sea breeze still brazenly slipped into her clothes, raising goosebumps on her delicate skin.

"When I went to bring her clothes before." Xu Qingzhu said: "She called and told me to bring them. I said I wouldn't go. She got very angry."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, but still recounted this matter calmly enough.

Actually, it was just some details from how they had gotten along before.

On their wedding night, she had already known that Liang Shi was cheating.

She really liked sleeping with women. The Omegas and Betas around her were too numerous to count.

Liang Shi had money, looked pretty good, and was always generous, so those women outside flocked to her.

After their marriage, their relationship had been deadlocked for a while. Liang Shi had also tried to coax her, but Xu Qingzhu was quite guarded, so Liang Shi hadn't succeeded in winning her over.

Having her deliver clothes to the bar was just an excuse—most likely she wanted her to loosen up in an environment where one could indulge in pleasure. After receiving the call, Xu Qingzhu had refused, but lying alone in the villa always made her uneasy. So on that rainy night, she drove out.

After arriving at the bar Liang Shi had mentioned, she endured her disgust and walked around inside, but couldn't find Liang Shi.

After leaving the bar, she called Liang Shi but heard the phone ringtone coming from not far away.

She followed the sound and found Liang Shi standing at the entrance of the bar with a woman...

That woman was Wang Ruoshi.

Liang Shi had her wrapped in her arms, kissing her brazenly.

Hearing the ringtone, Wang Ruoshi had even pushed her. "Aren't you going to answer the phone?"

Liang Shi's fingers deftly undid her buttons as she chuckled softly: "Don't want to."

Xu Qingzhu stood not far away, watching a scene more stimulating than anything in movies.

They didn't go all the way outside—they went into the car.

With her good hearing, she could even hear the overlapping sounds of their panting.

They weren't the only ones doing this at the bar entrance. Xu Qingzhu stood there for a long time, completely unaware of what kind of mood she had watched with, or what kind of mood she had driven home with.

In any case... for a period of time, she often had these disgusting dreams.

After hearing this, Liang Shi's heart was filled with mixed emotions.

"Don't worry." Liang Shi said: "I will definitely keep myself clean."

Xu Qingzhu glanced sideways at her. Those eyes glistening with moisture reflected the dim glow of the setting sun, charm flowing with each blink.

Xu Qingzhu smiled faintly. "I can sort of understand her now, I suppose."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

"She has a sex addiction." Xu Qingzhu said: "It's not right to judge a sick person by normal standards."

"Then can you forgive her?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very cold, blending into the biting wind. "I don't love her, so there's no question of forgiveness. In my heart, this marriage ended long ago."

Liang Shi: "...Alright."

At certain times, she felt that Xu Qingzhu was truly as rational as an AI.

But Liang Shi didn't understand. "Then why did you marry her in the first place? Just for the company's financing?"

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head slightly and gently pressed her lips together.

Her pink lips turned pale white for an instant, then slowly regained their color—looking very alluring.

Liang Shi lowered her eyes, not daring to keep looking.

But Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Teacher Liang might want to think carefully about that question."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "How is it that you can only remember Qi Jiao?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Chapter 85-4

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Xu Qingzhu's words had hidden meanings, as if she was playing riddles with her.

Liang Shi didn't understand, but Xu Qingzhu refused to say more, telling her there was no need to overthink it. Right now there was a pile of messes in front of them—they should deal with Qi Jiao's matter first.

As soon as she thought of Qi Jiao, Liang Shi's thoughts were diverted.

What could now be confirmed was that Qi Jiao was Gu Xingyue, and Liang Shi's speculation was largely correct.

Yang Jiani held leverage over the former Director Gu and used it to threaten Gu Xingyue, then made Gu Xingyue act as Qi Jiao's stand-in for all these years.

And the former Director Gu had once seen Yang Jiani abuse Gu Xingyue but was powerless to do anything. So after returning to the orphanage, she was consumed by guilt and eventually went insane.

After Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu all this information, Xu Qingzhu shook her head helplessly: "Now we can only wait for Gu Xingyue to figure things out. She's the most crucial person."

"Yes." Liang Shi said: "If you want others to save you, you have to save yourself first."

"But after going through so many years, even the strongest person would have been tamed. How could she possibly still have thoughts of resistance?" Xu Qingzhu sighed. "In a family like that, both Qi Jiao and Gu Xingyue are so pitiful."

"Yes." Liang Shi suddenly recalled the Qi Jiao she had seen in the dark dream and couldn't help but feel emotional. "When Qi Jiao was little, she was really like a little angel. I don't understand why Yang Jiani would treat her that way."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu raised her eyebrows slightly. "Hm? How was she like a little angel?"

Liang Shi paused for a moment, then told Xu Qingzhu about everything she had seen in that dream.

She said that Qi Jiao would secretly hide little cookies for her, would comfort her not to be afraid, would shield her when Yang Jiani hit her, and would go act cute and kiss Yang Jiani after Yang Jiani suffered domestic violence.

In summary, young Qi Jiao was very similar to Ling Dang now, but also had a hint of Rainbow's calm temperament mixed in.

After hearing this, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "If that's the case, then Yang Jiani killed the person who loved her most in this world with her own hands."

Listening to this, a tear suddenly fell from Liang Shi's eye.

Even she herself was startled.

"You seem to really like her." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi first shook her head, then nodded: "I don't seem to have many memories of spending time with her, but whenever I can remember, I feel very sad."

Especially since she was now looking at it from an adult's perspective.

Young Qi Jiao should have been at an age of carefree abandon, just like Ling Dang, but Qi Jiao had to comfort an unrelated little sister, console her beaten mother, and her own body was covered in injuries.

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment. "It is quite sad."

After that, she didn't say anything more.

The two still had an appointment to keep that evening. On the way back, Xu Qingzhu curled up in the passenger seat and took a nap.

Liang Shi played some soft music to help her sleep. The car drove all the way from the outskirts back to the city.

They first returned to the apartment. The moment Liang Shi pushed open the door, she saw the living room piled full of stuff.

Xu Qingzhu stood behind her, watching her with a leisurely expression that seemed to say—See? Look at what you did.

Liang Shi awkwardly rubbed her nose. "Let's do our makeup and change clothes first. If there's time when we get back tonight, I'll tidy up. If not, I'll do it tomorrow. Just bear with it for now."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "That's the only option."

Then the two went back to their respective rooms, but two seconds later, they both came out at the same time, looking at each other and asking the same question: "Do you want to shower first or should I?"

The bathroom here wasn't like at Repulse Bay where there were multiple ones—it was a shared bathroom.

So they had to take turns using it.

Liang Shi said: "You go first. I'll unpack and assemble the vanity tables."

Xu Qingzhu didn't stand on ceremony either. Time didn't allow them to dawdle.

Liang Shi's past life experience made her adept at these things. She quickly assembled the two identical vanity tables and put them in their respective rooms.

There was still time afterward, so she also unpacked the newly purchased furniture one by one and put them in Xu Qingzhu's bedroom. Her own bedroom just gained a vanity table.

After finishing, she also organized the cardboard boxes on the floor and swept the floor while she was at it.

When Xu Qingzhu came out after her shower, she discovered that the living room had suddenly become clean.

She was surprised: "You finished everything?"

Liang Shi nodded: "...Yes."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"It just looked like a lot." Liang Shi said: "There actually wasn't that much. I put everything directly in your room. If there's anything missing, we can add more."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She was impressed by Liang Shi's efficiency.

While Xu Qingzhu was doing her makeup, Liang Shi went to the bathroom to shower.

Xu Qingzhu had just finished showering, and the bathroom was still misty with steam. Upon entering, one could still smell the crisp scent of oranges—the smell of her shampoo.

Liang Shi glanced around and noticed that the shampoo, conditioner, and body wash on the shelf were all neatly arranged and from the same product line.

Her own bottles had basically been emptied before, so she hadn't brought them when she left Repulse Bay. She had originally planned to buy new ones after moving to the new place, but she had forgotten that day too. She poked her head out of the bathroom and asked: "Teacher Xu, can I use your shampoo and body wash?"

Xu Qingzhu answered: "Yes."

Liang Shi: "Okay, thank you."

She was being polite to the extreme.

After saying this, she closed the bathroom door. Xu Qingzhu, who was in her room applying body lotion, paused her movements for a moment. Her palm glided over her fair leg, spreading out a large dollop of white lotion. Her gaze swept toward the bathroom, and then she set aside her body lotion that was running low and didn't use any more.

Even though she hadn't applied any to her other leg yet.

What was left should be enough for one person. She'd leave it for Liang Shi, Xu Qingzhu thought.

Chapter 85-5

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The Su family's family relationships weren't complicated. Su Zhe and Su Yao were biological siblings, and their parents had passed away.

Su Zhe had an uncle, but their relationship wasn't good. Years ago, Su Zhe and his cousin had a huge argument, and the uncle had taken his whole family to emigrate. They hadn't been in contact for many years.

The rest were some side branches of the family, all dependent on Haiwei Jewelry for their livelihood, and they wouldn't be appearing at this family banquet.

The closer relatives were Su Zhe's children—his daughter Su Meiqi and his son Su Nan.

Su Meiqi was one year older than Xu Qingzhu, and Su Nan was four years younger than Xu Qingzhu.

And then there was her biological younger sister, Sheng Yu.

It felt both strange and wonderful. She was clearly old enough to be a mother herself, yet she inexplicably had gained a five-year-old biological sister.

But Xu Qingzhu also felt that Su Yao's love was truly touching.

Especially after Sheng Linlang had told her so many things—she felt that Su Yao was the most pitiful one.

Sheng Qinglin had passed away knowing nothing.

But he had left Su Yao behind in pain, growing old while guarding their memories.

She appeared to still be alive, but in reality had become a soulless shell.

What Xu Qingzhu was most concerned about was whether Su Yao had any lingering health issues after giving birth to Sheng Yu, since she had been of advanced maternal age after all.

Fortunately, Su Yao had pulled through and safely given birth to Sheng Yu, gaining a new emotional anchor.

On the evening of this family recognition banquet, Su Yao also came.

Under the strong emotional stimulus, she had recovered some of her memories.

She remembered that she still had a daughter, but she didn't remember how her daughter had left her. Su Zhe lied to her, saying that the Sheng family's older sister had seen that her condition wasn't good at the time, so she had helped raise her daughter. Now that her daughter had grown up and her own condition had stabilized, the Sheng family's older sister was willing to let her reunite with her daughter.

After hearing this, Su Yao sighed with emotion: "Linlang is so kind."

Su Zhe nearly choked on a mouthful of blood, but for his sister's sake, he had no choice but to tell this well-intentioned lie.

This explanation was thought up by his wife. At first, he had strongly opposed it.

But his wife said that in the future, Xu Qingzhu would need to maintain relationships with both sides. They couldn't avoid this, so they should try to let go of past resentments and establish a good relationship. The Sheng family's older sister wasn't a bad person.

If the Su family's attitude was too unyielding, the one who would feel caught in the middle in the end would still be Xu Qingzhu.

After all, fundamentally speaking, the ones who had been raising Xu Qingzhu all these years were the Sheng family's older sister and brother-in-law.

After thinking it over, Su Zhe was persuaded.

The only people who came that evening were Su Zhe and his wife, the Su Meiqi siblings, Su Yao, and Sheng Yu.

When Xu Qingzhu brought Liang Shi in, the family members who had been sitting in the private room all stood up—except for the bewildered Sheng Yu.

But it was still Sheng Yu who ran over first. She stared at Liang Shi again and again, tilted her head and asked: "Rainbow's mama's colleague, are you really my older sister?"

"I'm not." Liang Shi turned her head around. "This one is your real older sister."

Sheng Yu: "..."

Sheng Yu made a bitter gourd face¹. "But she's so fierce. Can't you be my older sister instead?"

Liang Shi picked her up in one swoop. "How is she fierce? She's clearly very gentle."

Sheng Yu frowned: "Jiejie², do you need to get your eyes checked?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Sheng Yu." Su Zhe called out to her coldly: "Don't be rude."

"Uncle." Sheng Yu pouted pitifully, looking pathetic. But then Su Meiqi came over and patted her bottom. "Can you be a polite child?"

Sheng Yu felt wronged. "You're all bullying me."

"Who told you to talk about me?" Xu Qingzhu stood in front of her, then reached out toward Liang Shi. Liang Shi handed the child over to her.

Sheng Yu had wanted to resist, but after Xu Qingzhu held her, her head accidentally ended up buried in Xu Qingzhu's neck.

A few seconds later, she said in surprise: "Jiejie, you smell so nice."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Are you going to say mean things about me again?" Xu Qingzhu asked her.

Sheng Yu bit her lip, trying to negotiate with her. "Then you can't be mean to me."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Fine."

Sheng Yu wrapped her arms around her neck. "Can you hold me the whole time?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

This little brat's change of attitude was way too fast.

Xu Qingzhu could only respond helplessly: "I can hold you for a little while tonight."

"Only a little while?" Sheng Yu was aggrieved again.

Su Meiqi said from the side: "Sheng Yu baby, don't you have any idea how heavy you are? How do you still dare to ask people to hold you all the time?"

Sheng Yu retorted fiercely: "I'm not that heavy! I just eat a lot!"

Su Nan, who had been quiet and silent the whole time, stood up and walked over, opening his arms to Sheng Yu. "Come here, I'll hold you."

Sheng Yu sniffled, utterly conflicted.

She buried her face in Xu Qingzhu's neck and took another sniff. "Jiejie smells so nice."

Only then did she reluctantly go to Su Nan.

Su Nan was tall, had delicate features, was a man of few words, and hadn't greeted Xu Qingzhu either.

Xu Qingzhu had already spoken with everyone here before, but this formal of an occasion was the first time.

Fortunately, there was the little imp Sheng Yu who had broken the ice ahead of time, so it wasn't too awkward.

Footnotes:

¹ **Bitter gourd face (苦瓜臉):** A Chinese expression describing a face scrunched up in displeasure or looking very unhappy, resembling the wrinkled surface of a bitter gourd/melon.

² **Jiejie (姐姐):** Meaning "older sister" in Chinese, used here by Sheng Yu to address Liang Shi, even though they're not related. It's a common respectful/affectionate way for children to address older females.

Chapter 85-6

After Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi were seated, Su Zhe had the server bring out the dishes.

Very soon, the table was piled with all kinds of dishes. Sheng Yu nestled in Su Nan's arms and started eating.

Su Zhe cleared his throat and began: "Then today, we officially become one family."

Xu Qingzhu looked at him, picked up the wine glass in front of her, poured just a little to show her sincerity, and called Su Zhe "uncle."

After going around greeting everyone, the last one remaining was Su Yao.

Su Yao's eyes had already turned red as she looked at her. Xu Qingzhu had originally been looking at her from across the table, and seeing Su Yao's reddened eyes, she couldn't help but feel sad along with her.

When it came to Su Yao's turn, Xu Qingzhu stood up and sat down beside Su Yao, then took the initiative to hold Su Yao's hand. But the word "Mom" just wouldn't come out no matter what.

"Are you... really my daughter?" Su Yao asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Yes."

The private room fell completely silent. Everyone was watching the two of them. Xu Qingzhu's tears fell.

She had thought she was strong enough—strong enough not to cry even when seeing Su Yao cry.

But she hadn't expected that when she held Su Yao's hand, she would be the first one to cry.

Su Yao hurriedly grabbed tissues to wipe her tears, comforting her in a low voice: "Little Zhuzi¹, don't cry."

This intimate nickname made Xu Qingzhu's heart ache unbearably.

She had followed Sheng Linlang's words through the long love story of Sheng Qinglin and Su Yao, and she knew what Su Yao had experienced.

Now sitting beside Su Yao, Xu Qingzhu hadn't expected to hear "Little Zhuzi."

Her name was Qingzhu—unyielding and unbreaking, forever verdant.

It was the name her parents had given her, full of hope.

And for a very long time, Su Yao had kept "Little Zhuzi" in her heart and mind, yet had no one to miss. Year after year, she would look at the verdant bamboo outside her window, not knowing who she was longing for.

In this moment, all that longing finally had a place to land.

Xu Qingzhu opened her mouth and called out with difficulty: "Mom."

Su Yao nodded in acknowledgment: "Ai."²

Sheng Yu, who was nearby, jumped down from Su Nan's arms and toddled over on her little short legs to hand Su Yao a tissue. "Mama, don't cry."

After looking at Xu Qingzhu, she handed another tissue to Xu Qingzhu. "Nice-smelling jiejie, don't cry."

This made Xu Qingzhu not know whether to laugh or cry.

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The dinner went smoothly. Xu Qingzhu sat beside Su Yao the entire time.

She had originally thought that as she was now grown up, she could take care of Su Yao. But unexpectedly, Su Yao kept putting food on her plate the whole time—she was the one being taken care of.

Watching their reunion from inside the private room, Liang Shi thought of her grandparents. It felt a bit stuffy staying in the room, so she used the excuse of going to the restroom to leave.

She went to the corridor to get some air, leaning against the wall by herself in a daze.

Suddenly, a crisp voice rang out in the corridor: "Why can't you break up with her? Whatever she can give you, I can give you too."

Liang Shi glanced sideways and saw a woman standing on the stairs wearing a black slip dress, her long hair draped over her shoulders. She was like a thorny black rose.

Liang Shi felt this wasn't a place to linger and was about to leave, but the woman had already hung up the phone and instead asked: "Hey, got a light?"

It didn't sound polite at all, but it didn't come across as arrogant either.

As it happened, Liang Shi had a lighter in her coat pocket—a one-yuan lighter she'd bought downstairs at their residential complex to light incense.

Liang Shi hesitated for a few seconds but still chose to hand the lighter to her.

The woman pinched out a cigarette from her pack. Her red nails weren't tacky; instead, they had a kind of glamorous beauty.

She lit the cigarette but didn't return the lighter to Liang Shi. Instead, she pinched out another cigarette and offered it to Liang Shi. Liang Shi waved her hand. "I don't smoke."

The woman didn't push it. After taking a puff and blowing out a smoke ring, she then waved her hand and, looking somewhat dissatisfied, stubbed out the cigarette. "This cigarette is really harsh," she said with displeasure.

Liang Shi couldn't help but say: "Then why smoke it?"

"Didn't I just put it out?" the woman said. "You..."

Her words trailed off mid-sentence. She pointed at Liang Shi. "Wait, your face..."

"What about it?" Liang Shi asked.

The woman frowned. "Your eyes are quite pretty."

It was clearly meant as a compliment, but the way she said it was so bland that you couldn't tell it was a compliment.

Liang Shi also responded perfunctorily: "Thanks."

The woman put away her graceful and casual posture and returned the lighter to Liang Shi. "No need for thanks."

Then she looked at Liang Shi. "What's your name?"

"Liang Shi." Liang Shi answered. "Do you know me?"

"I don't." The woman's voice was cool and flippant. "But now I do, as of today."

She paused for a moment. "My name is Gu Yixue."

After saying this, she pulled open the door. As she was leaving, she chuckled softly: "Oh, by the way, eavesdropping on people's phone calls isn't a good habit."

Liang Shi: "..."

"If we meet again next time, I'll give you a more expensive lighter." Gu Yixue said.

Footnotes:

¹ **Little Zhuzi (小竹子):** An affectionate nickname meaning "Little Bamboo." "Zhu" (竹) means bamboo, which is also part of Xu Qingzhu's name. "Qingzhu" (清竹) means "clear/pure bamboo" or "verdant bamboo."

² **Ai (哎):** A Chinese interjection used to acknowledge being called, similar to answering "yes" or "here" when someone calls your name. It's a warm, familial response typically used by elders when a younger person addresses them.